economic prosperity for the whole region. From India's perspective, SCO membership would open a new opportunity to reconnect with Eurasia after a century of disruption. At the 2016 SCO Summit in Tashkent, Prime Minister Modi stated that India looks forward to a fruitful engagement in the SCO. India's entry into SCO as a full member, he said, will provide an opportunity to have extended cooperation with member countries in the areas of defence, security, and counter-terrorism. He said India attaches great importance to ties with Central Asia and always seeks to expand economic and people-to-people ties with the region.[6]

Second, joining the SCO could help India minimise the intensity of the China–Pakistan alignment that actually undercuts its direct access to Eurasia and get out of the current tight geopolitical spot, wedged between a wall of Pakistani hostility and fear of cooperating with China. India could use the atmosphere of cooperation in SCO to turn around India's relationship with China in a big way. Moreover, as India's concerns are essentially security driven, joining the SCO would reduce the risk of if being used as a smokescreen by inimical forces, including Pakistan, to drum up support for anti-India activities.

Third, India could also use the SCO as a useful means to reboot its relationship with Russia, which has been losing its vibrancy. As India's engagement with the United States grows, it must avoid Russian resentment, and, compared to China, India is unable to help Russia overcome its economic isolation. Furthermore, Russia and Pakistan have been increasingly building bridges, the contours of which are not clear yet. However, India could use the SCO for building better convergence with Russia in the Eurasian space through trade (India–EAEU, FTA) and transport connectivity (INSTC), which are under speedy implementation. More importantly, India and Russia should take up joint projects in